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Introduction to Contemporary German Philosophy

"Hermeneutics as a practical philosophy" by Hans-Georg Gadamer

The aim of this work is to discuss an extract of "Reason in the age of science"[Gad76], Gadamer's argument to prove hermeneutics as a practical science.

The discussion is introduced by claiming that the topic had a recent relevance that must be traced to the broadest definition of Hermeneutics as "the theory or art of explication, of interpretation"[Gad76]. We can already notice two important concepts that will be studied later: art (*kunstlehre*, meaning a *practical* art) and theory. This duality can be first seen in Aristotle between "practical philosophy" (praxis) and "theoretical philosophy" (theoria). For Aristotle philosophy denotes science in the broadest sense, so the distinction between the two is that the theoretical sciences form the base ground for the practical sciences, which are the applications; for example, theoretical sciences are mathematics, physics and metaphysics while a practical science is political science. We may notice that this duality is not a contraposition of the concepts since the methods used are not in contrast, we might say that "theory is a form of practice" to study the "eternal structures of reality". What distinguishes practice for human beings is the concept of *prohairesis*, which means "prior choice" in the context of making a choice for, what Aristotle calls *arete*, the "good in itself", the right thing. *Prohairesis*, writes Gadamer, separates practice from what the Greeks called *techne* which is the "acquired skill of the expert"[Gad76], an automatic reaction which does not require a choice or decision. We deduce therefore that practice is an action (from the Greek *praxis*) while technical skills are just a repetition of automatic instructions.

If we subscribe to Aristotle definition of science: "a knowledge of the universal that as such is teachable"[Ari??], then practical sciences have some connotations of the techne, for example the teaching, but differ due to the choice for what's "good", the research for the arete, for example political science asks "about the best way of life or about the best constitution of the state"[Gad76].

All this holds true for hermeneutics as well. It has a normative nature, a set of rules used to decode or interpret texts: old hermeneutics was used for theology to understand the sacred texts or, in jurisprudence, to apply laws faithfully.

Another example of the application of hermeneutics in past times, with a normative connotation, was the study of classics. During the new humanism, the re-discovery of ancient Greek, Latin and Hebrew brought the need for a discipline that studied grammar, lexicon and historical context to decode the meanings of the texts. Beyond the informational aspect the study of the classics started to question whether taking for granted what was written in the texts.

This "hermeneutical awakening"[Gad76], as Gadamer calls it, can be seen in the "querelle des anciens et des modernes", the debate between the ancients and the moderns, a famous quarrel between two factions of intellectuals in France of 17th century where the faction of the "ancients" thought that the scriptures had to be put under scrutiny as it was done for classical texts. From this discussion we can also notice that hermeneutics does not carry an easy understanding of the object of study but opens a debate and further questions, this property separates it from the pure normative use and carries interesting consequences for all the practical philosophies: "If, for example, ethics is a teaching about the right way to live, it still presupposes its concretization within a living ethos"[Gad76].

In the post-Romantic era hermeneutics grew closer to the natural sciences, with Gadamer's words: "the transmitted texts, were to be treated like the observational data in the scientific investigation of nature"[Gad76], so there was disregard for subjective aspects. In this period Schleiermacher separates hermeneutics from dialectics and the technical skills of hermeneutics from faith (in theology).

Gadamer traces the growing importance of hermeneutics to the rise of "radical doubt and critique"[Gad76] which is led by who Ricœur will later identify with the term "school of suspicion" ("*école du soupçon*"[Ric95]): Nietzsche, Freud and Marx.

Nietzsche has put in discussion the explicit self-knowledge as the foundation of all certitude, which was also sustained by the discovery of psychoanalysis.

Another kind of interpretation that pertains hermeneutics is the interpretation of data or a certain phenomenon. Inside this branch we can see the role of Marxism in doubting religion as a tool for the dominant class to maintain control over the proletariat.

Another key figure in the hermeneutical awakening is Martin Heidegger. When he states that modern thought was shaped by the unexplicated concept of consciousness and that is the key to grasp the concept of "being" (*sein*). In the lecture "What is Metaphysics"[Hei29] Heidegger argues that metaphysics never argued the concept of "being itself" (*di Frage nach dem Sein*): to answer the question "what is metaphysics?" one must understand "what happened with the beginning of

metaphysical thinking"[Gad76] and this reformulation assumes the form of a new notion of interpretation and subsequentially of hermeneutics.

This concept of "self-understanding" can be found both in Fichte's and Hegel's philosophy and is given as a complete knowledge granted by ego (for Fichte) or by a dialectic procedure (for Hegel).

Gadamer dismissed both these ideas by claiming that self-understanding can no longer be a complete self-transparency anymore of the discoveries of the school of doubt: "Self-understanding is always on-the-way; it is on a path whose completion is a clear impossibility"[Gad76].

Once we assume that there is no such thing as a fully transparent text or phenomenon then all perspectives relative to hermeneutics are shifted. The question that guided us to a given subject becomes the only insightful understanding of the subject itself. One key insight of modern hermeneutics is that every statement must be seen as a response to question (given by its preconditions) and the only way to understand a statement is to get a hold of the questions of which the statement is the answer. But that is not all. Given a question about our presuppositions regarding a certain phenomenon, if it is a legitimate question, if it has a motivation, it must be grounded on some kind statements answering themselves other questions about their own presuppositions, and so on. We can reduce this reasoning, which builds what Gadamer calls the "pre-structure of understanding"[Gad60 (*struktur des Verstehens*)], to asking and infinite succession of questions originating from our object of interest, where every question is grounded on the presuppositions of the next. This process can at most lead to a progressive better understanding of our object of interest, without grasping a complete knowledge of it, as already mentioned, since the pre structure of understanding is superior to men; not only because the process cannot end but because our understanding is mediated by history or contingent things which are volatile.

Gadamer then concludes by explaining that what he denotes as philosophical hermeneutics is not just understanding and explain a concept (substilitas intelligendi et explicandi) but "it only describes what always happens wherever an interpretation is convincing and successful", it is not a matter of a technical skill, rather is an acknowledgement that vague presuppositions always play a role in our understanding, making it philosophy, a practical philosophy.

Bibliography

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